

THE RED WAVES OF revolution

THE RISE OF COMMUNISM

Although Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels did not directly address gender inequalities in their groundbreaking political pamphlet, *The Communist Manifesto* (1848), they did assess women's position in society as part of the class struggle. They demonstrated that women's lives were shaped by their status as an underclass within a class (the proletariat) due to most women's work being unpaid or underpaid. The first Marxist work to solely address the situation of women in Russia was *The Woman Worker* (1899) by Nadezhda Krupskaya, wife of the Soviet revolutionary leader Vladimir Ilyich Ulyanov, better known as Lenin. Krupskaya maintained that women's liberation was only possible through their participation in the class struggle.

German Marxist Clara Zetkin declared March 8 International Women's Day in 1910

It was a women's protest in 1917 that helped spark the Russian Revolution. On March 2, 1917 (February 18, according to the old Russian calendar), workers at a factory in

Petrograd (now St. Petersburg) announced a strike against the government. On March 8 (February 23, old calendar), female peasants, students, and workers protested over hunger and Russia's participation in World War I (see pp. 200–203).

This “bread and peace” strike had been called for by the socialist women's journal *Rabotnitsa*. Slogans on

women's banners demanded “Feed the children of the defenders of the motherland!” In the afternoon, the women were joined by striking female textile workers and their menfolk, swelling the crowd to 100,000. The protest developed into a general strike, in which women clashed with the forces of the Petrograd garrison. Soldiers, unwilling to beat and shoot women, then joined the protest, turning it into an anti-government uprising that started the February Revolution and toppled the czar. In October, Lenin then led the Bolsheviks to overthrow the provisional government.

The woman who shot Lenin

Not everyone accepted the Bolshevik victory. Fanny Kaplan, originally an anarchist and later a member of the Socialist Revolutionary Party (SRP), believed that Lenin had betrayed the revolution when he excluded other left-wing political parties from power. Kaplan attempted to shoot Lenin on August 30, 1918, but Lenin survived and Kaplan was executed.

► Traitor?

This painting depicts Fanny Kaplan's failed attempt on Lenin's life in 1918. She was executed having refused to name her accomplices, but she is thought to have acted for the SRP.

